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The Igbo of southeast Nigeria

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Marriage and Social Position • The Status of Women

Marriage and Social Position

Married status is an important variable in the status configuration of the Igbo. Married life is the normal condition for adults, and polygyny for the men is the ideal, being an important status indicator. The Igbo who remains single does so not out of choice but because of economic necessity: the inability to provide the bridewealth payment. The unmarried adult male is referred to as *oke okporo* (male woman), a pejorative term, while the unmarried woman is referred to by a descriptive phrase—*Onwegh di* ("She has no husband"). Widows are referred to as *ishi nkpe* ("Mourning head") and form part of the marriageable population. Igbo is a society which has no concept of celibacy but tolerates celibates as victims of economic forces.

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Polygyny has obvious status implications for the common husband and his co-wives. Igbo women support and often even finance polygyny because it enhances their social status and lightens their domestic chores, thus giving them the much-needed leisure to do their private trading. With a co-wife, the first wife assumes the coveted status of *nnekwu* ("The big mother"). Other co-wives are ranked in seniority according to their marriage order to the common husband. In this marriage-order ranking, age, wealth, fertility, positions, and prospects of offspring of the co-wife are not factors. They are, nevertheless, important status variables, especially in the interpersonal and extrafamilial relations of the co-wives concerned. In the wider Igbo society, those variables may take precedence over the marriage order. A woman may be highly ranked because of the position of a distinguished son, her success in trading, or her position in the women's title society, irrespective of her marriage order.

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Indeed, some women are ranked higher than their husbands because of their distinctions in other spheres. Wealthy women marry in their own right, found big compounds, and play the role of social father quite effectively.

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Polygyny has its tensions. The interests of a husband often conflict with those of his wives. Women tend to exclude men from their leisure activities. Their virilocal residence after marriage and other sex-linked roles tend to create a distinct sex subculture. A husband is often a victim of concerted action by his wives, an action that might force him into submission. This situation may be ameliorated by the *nwanyimma*, the love wife. She remains the confidante of the husband and enjoys a special status, but she is also a target of abuse and gossip by other co-wives.

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The Status of Women

The women members of an Igbo village are of two categories: the *omokpof*, who may be unmarried, married, divorced, or widowed women who belong to the village by descent, and the *ndom alθ alθ* who belong to it by marriage. The rule that women should always be married gives marriage the [87](#) precedence over descent. The relation between these two classes of women is one of "potential" conflict covertly expressed in the joking relationship between them and overtly manifested in the institutionalized authority of the *omokpof* over the *ndom alθ alθ* during the mourning rites marking the latter's widowhood.

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